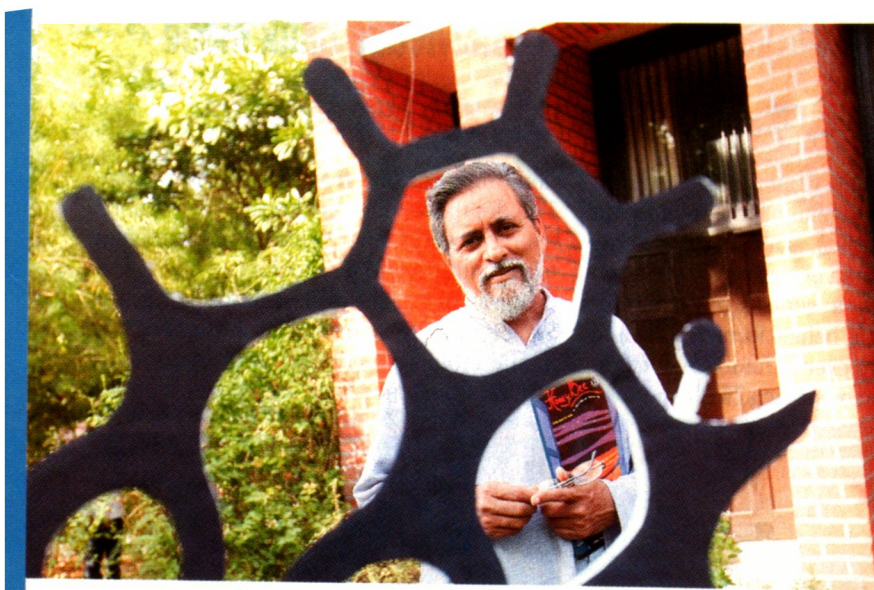


by Gupta in 1993, have had a profound impact on society. A recent one is a windmill made of bamboo and tin sheets that costs just Rs 25,000. Designed by two Assamese brothers, Mehtar Hussain and Mustaque Hussain, to pump water into their farm at a low cost, the windmill will now help poor salt workers of the Rann of Kutch in Gujarat draw water from the earthbed with no running costs, a relief from the huge amounts spent on fuel for diesel pumps.

Another discovery is that made by a tribal of a local plant leaf in Orissa that helps ripen fruits in a natural, organic way. It will prove useful to the food-processing industry



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India's villages are full of unsung heroes who have solved problems on their own. Society has to start believing in them.

ANIL K. GUPTA, Vice-chairman, NIF

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as a substitute for the chemicals that are currently used in ripening fruits.

A Hindi-medium school student born in a village of Uttar Pradesh, Gupta did his M.Sc. in agrogenetics from Haryana Agricultural University before starting work as an agriculture officer in a bank. He later sought to introduce development opportunities in drought-prone districts of the

country from 1978 to 1981. Soon he was IIM-A teaching agriculture as an assistant professor before doing his doctorate in management from Kurukshetra University Haryana in 1986. The turning point for him came when he went to Bangladesh as part of a research project that aimed at enabling scientists to learn from common people and work with them in developing technology.

Says Gupta, who draws inspiration from Mahatma Gandhi and his vision of village development: "I already had a great belief in the innovative potential of common people. But it was during this Bangladesh project that I developed a clear vision and realised that rural areas were full of unsung heroes who had solved local technological problems on their own and a belief had to be created in society about the creativity of these grassroots innovators." Gupta's mission was now fixed on developing a nationwide movement for the purpose.

The first step was the Honeybee network that he jointly founded in 1990 with a few IIMA professors and some farmers in Gujarat. It was an informal association of volunteers who believed in societal innovative potential. When the Honeybee network had made a database of about 500 people and around 5,000 innovations, Gupta founded SRISTI to give organisational support to Honeybee. Next came the creation of a joint initiative of SRISTI, IIMA and the government of Gujarat in the form of the Grassroots Innovation Augmentation Network (GIAN), an incubator for innovations and a facilitator of linkages to enterprise and investment.

The big jump for Gupta's great dream came in 2000 when the then NDA government agreed to set up NIF with a corpus of Rs 20 crore. The interest from the corpus helps in giving commercial shape to grassroots innovation. For Gupta, who talks about protecting the intellectual property rights of the poor in his Honeybee network editorials much before the World Trade Organisation and Convention of Biological Diversity, NIF is a Government-supported institution that works like an NGO without losing the spirit of voluntarism. Gupta is now trying hard to get the corpus increased to Rs 200 crore.

By giving shape to a model of development which has the rural village at its heart, the IIMA professor has done more than most to manage the Mahatma's vision in contemporary India.